things and of their movement that *today* seems so natural to us is not an ancient intuition that is natural to humanity itself. It's an idea of Newton's.

The majority of philosophers have in fact responded negatively to this idea. In a still celebrated, furious counterblast, Leibniz defended the traditional thesis according to which time is only the order of events, arguing that there is no such thing as an autonomous time. Legend has it that Leibniz, whose name is still occasionally spelled with a "t" (Leibnitz), had deliberately dropped the letter from his name in accordance with his belief in the *nonexistence* of the absolute Newtonian time *t*.[48]

Before Newton, time for humanity was the way of counting how things changed. Before him, no one had thought it possible that a time independent of things could exist. Don't take your intuitions and ideas to be "natural": they are often the products of the ideas of audacious thinkers who came before us.

But of these two giants, Aristotle and Newton, was it really Newton who was right? What exactly is this "time" that he introduced, managing to convince the entire world that it exists, one that works so brilliantly well in his equations and yet is *not* the time that we perceive?

To get out from between these two giants, and in a strange way to reconcile them, a third was needed. Before getting to him, however, a brief digression on space is in order.

WHAT IS THERE, WHERE THERE IS NOTHING?

The two interpretations of time (the measure of "when" with regard to events, as Aristotle wanted; the entity that runs even when nothing happens, according to Newton) can be repeated for space. Time is what we speak of when we ask "when?" Space is what we speak of when we ask "where?" If I ask "Where is the Coliseum?" one possible answer is: "It's in Rome." If I ask "Where are you?" a possible answer might be: "At home." To reply to the question "Where is something?" means to indicate something else that is *around* that thing. If I say "In the Sahara," you will visualize me surrounded by sand dunes.

Aristotle was the first to discuss in depth and with acuity the meaning of "space," or "place," and to arrive at a precise definition: the place of a thing is what surrounds that thing.[49]

As in the case of time, Newton suggests that we should think differently. The space defined by Aristotle, the enumeration of what surrounds each thing, is called "relative, apparent, and common" by Newton. He calls "absolute,